Three First Moves for Looking at Your Mother's Support

Map the week, name what it counts on, pick what to raise. And what can wait.

Your mother is doing fine at home. Your sister drives her on Tuesdays, the neighbor looks in most mornings, you come on Sundays, and you've been meaning to look at how it all fits together. Nothing has happened, so it's hard to know where to begin.

Begin here. Three moves, in this order, at whatever pace suits the family.

1 Map an ordinary week

Write the seven days down the side of a page. Beside each, put who is with your mother or looks in on her, and what they do: the Tuesday drive, the neighbor's knock most mornings, your Sunday visit. Leave a blank where nobody comes. Then show her the page and ask what you've missed. AARP's planning guide says a family's plan should never be made without the participation and knowledge of the person it's about. [1]

WHY IT COMES HERE The other two moves are written onto this page. And a routine that runs smoothly is hard to see until someone writes it down.

2 Name what each part counts on

Beside each name, write one line that begins “This works as long as…”: your sister's Tuesdays stay free, the neighbor stays next door. Then ask each helper how it's going on their end, and write down what they tell you. AARP suggests each person consider what they are prepared and not prepared to do. Where nobody could cover for someone, write “nobody identified yet” and leave it there for now. [1]

WHY IT COMES HERE You can only ask about an assumption once it has been said out loud, and the map shows you whom to ask.

3 Pick what to raise, and with whom

List the small things you've noticed, each as what you saw and when: a hand on the wall in the hallway on Sunday, pills still in Tuesday's slot on Thursday. Beside each, write who could hear about it. The CDC's brochure for family caregivers says to talk openly with your mother and her healthcare provider about falls, and to show a provider or pharmacist all of her medications. Other questions can go on the list for your care consultant. [2]

WHY IT COMES HERE A concern written as what you saw is easy to bring up at an ordinary appointment, and writing it down keeps it from being forgotten or inflated.

Then put a date on the page

Write today's date at the top and agree on what will bring the family back to it. The CDC suggests updating a written care plan every year, or more often after a change in health or medicines. A family's page can borrow that rhythm and add one reason of its own: a change in the life of anyone on the map. [3]

What can wait

- Whether the arrangement is enough. A page of notes can't say, and this guide doesn't ask.
- Finding a backup for everyone. For now, “nobody identified yet” is a complete answer.
- Any change to her home, her routine or her medicines.
- Who in the family should take on what. These moves ask people. They don't assign anyone anything.
- Anything about where she lives.

If something won't sit on a list

A list is for small things. If something worries you on the day you see it, call her doctor's office and describe it. An emergency is a call to emergency services.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't judge how your mother is managing, whether her home is safe, or whether anything should change. It gives a family with time three places to begin, in order.

Ready for the next step?

You've put the week on a page, named what each part counts on and picked what to raise. The care interview goes further: it asks about supervision, falls, medication handling, the home and each helper's capacity in a set order, so the map is checked against a full set of questions and not only the ones that came to mind, and it turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Showing your mother the page and asking each helper what they are and aren't prepared to do follow AARP's planning guide. Talking with her healthcare provider about falls and showing a provider or pharmacist her medications follow the CDC's brochure for family caregivers. The yearly review follows the CDC's guidance on written care plans, which we've borrowed for a family's page. The week on a page, the "as long as" lines and the order are ours.

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Family Caregivers: Protect Your Loved Ones from Falling (STEADI brochure, 2018)
3. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan

From the Family Care Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.